

and I concur. When you are paying close to ₹40,000 for a pair of headphones, you expect them to be packed with premium materials. Maybe, it is the finish on the plastic, that makes it feel this way. Or maybe we have been spoiled by the excellent build of the Sennheiser headphones that have come in the past. Don't be mistaken, the plastic, regardless of its feel, is robust. Trust me, I twisted and turned these headphones to the extremes. The cables are also built with quality materials and the connectors are gold plated. On the topic of connectors, you can switch the side to which you connect the cable to on these headphones, which is a boon for people working in studios.

The only gripe that I have with the design of these headphones is their portability. The case, is bulky and takes up a lot of space. No doubt, it is well built and I am sure that it will keep the headphones safe from a 5-foot drop as well. It has ample storage as well. But, for me, personally, a lighter case, with a bit less volume, would be a better deal. I understand that they were thinking of the pros when building these headphones that travel with pelican cases full of audio gear. But, for us regular folk, who enjoy using headphones that are built to be like the Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus, it would have been great to have an option for a slimmer and less bulky case.

PERFORMANCE

You may have noticed that there is no features section in this review of the Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus. That is because, with wired headphones, there is not much that we find in terms of "features". There are little creature comforts that the brands bake into the headphones, which complement their performance. So, I have combined the features section of this review with the performance section.

Unlike all the other headphones, there are two sound signatures that you get with these headphones. With the production earpads, you get a slightly warmer tone to the sound and with

the mixing earpads, these headphones sound more neutral and have the low-end cutout. See for yourself in the sound signature graphs below –

The mixing earpads lead the headphones to produce a more neutral sound, with the a boost in the highs, around the 4,000 Hz mark, which is characteristic of Sennheiser's headphones. If you read my review of the Sennheiser HD 300 Pro, which are my daily drivers at work, you find the same boost in the highs. The brand likes their sound to be a bit sparkly out of the box, which is totally fine. Put on the producing earpads, and you will see that the sound signature gets warmer. While the change might seem subtle in the graphs here, the difference is very noticeable, especially if you are working with or listening to bass-heavy music/content.

All in all, these headphones are one of the best headphones that I have heard in my two years of working with audio products. If you are a fan of neutral sounding pair of headphones, then you do not need to look any further. The soundstage on these headphones is expansive, given their open-back design. However, where these headphones shine, is the localisation. Localisation is nothing, but a measure of the spatial positioning of the audio, especially speech around your head. With these headphones, you will be pleasantly surprised, how well Sennheiser has managed to get this right.

Sennheiser has also added in a dearVR MIX-SE license with these headphones. It is essentially an add on for your Digital Audio Workstation or DAW, and helps you simulate a professional mixing space on your laptop or the device that you are working with. I would leave the experts to decide on the efficacy of this plugin. However, seeing this being added in, makes the case for these headphones even stronger.

Now, as you might have read in the earlier part of the review. These headphones are great for gaming as well. I play a lot of Counter-Strike, and for that, I use the SteelSeries Arctis Nova Pro headphones. And, when I got

these headphones, I took them out for a spin, and I have never looked back. The positioning of the audio in games, even in fast paced titles like Metal: Hellsinger is something that I was in awe of. Want the best of both worlds – high quality sound and a great gaming experience? Well, these headphones might be the right fit for you. But, make sure to check the fit first.

VERDICT

So, should you buy the Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus? Well, for me, it is a yes. The headphones sport a versatile sound signature, and literally hit two birds with one stone. They are comfortable and well-built. With the HD 490 Pro, Sennheiser has managed to build a truly unique product, which stands out from its competitors. While it helps the brand stand out, for folks looking to have a pair of headphones that they can game with, produce music with, or use in a studio for mixing, the Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus make for a great deal as well. Most headphones are able to cover just one or two of the above-listed uses.

So, when you are getting a product that does it all, then why not go for it? The only pair of headphones that I can think off the top of my head, that will stand against the Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus, will be the Beyerdynamic - DT 900 PRO X or Sennheiser's own Sennheiser - HD 660S2, which again, are not as versatile as these headphones.

–Satvik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Acoustic principle open: Ear coupling circumaural | Transducer principle dynamic: Transducer 38 mm | Transmission range: 5 Hz to 36, 100 Hz (-10 dB) | Sensitivity: 105 dB SPL (1 kHz/1 Vrms), 96 dB SPL (1 kHz/1 mW) | Max. sound pressure level: 128 dB SPL (1 kHz 5 % THD) | Distortion (THD): <0.2 % (1 kHz, 100 dB SPL) | Impedance: 130 Ω (1 kHz) | Power rating: 300 mW (100 h, noise IEC 60268) | Temperature range operation: +0 to +50 °C | storage: -25 to +70 °C | Rel. humidity operation: 10 to 80% not condensing storage: 10 to 90% | Weight (w/o cable): 260 g

CONTACT

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